



Understanding Trauma

Trauma is the lasting emotional response that often results from living through a distressing event. This guide helps community leaders recognize trauma and respond with compassion.

The Brain's Response

When an individual experiences trauma, the brain's alarm system takes over. This often results in three automatic responses:

- ✓ **Fight:** Aggression, defensiveness, or hyper-vigilance.
- ✓ **Flight:** Avoidance, fleeing a situation, or extreme anxiety.
- ✓ **Freeze:** Numbing out, disconnecting, or inability to make decisions.

Core Principles of Support

1. **Safety:** Ensuring physical and emotional safety is the top priority.
2. **Trustworthiness:** Maintaining clear boundaries and consistency.
3. **Choice:** Returning a sense of control to the individual.
4. **Collaboration:** Making decisions *with* them, not *for* them.